

THE HUMAN ERROR

A PLAY IN TWO ACTS

CHARACTERS

- **TILLY** — mid-30s, a programmer/systems administrator. Single mother to one child, Lottie, who never appears onstage but is talked about constantly. Keen amateur photographer. Sharp, tired, principled but frightened.
- **PAM** — Tilly's mother, turning 60 this year. Works in a shop, retiring in the next year or two. Modest savings. Warm, blunt, practical. **Heard only** — every one of Pam's scenes is a phone call. She never appears onstage.
- **GAZ** — 48, team manager in Customer Services at the same company (different department to Tilly). Runs and does trampolining. Gay, recently active on a dating app, looking for a man to share his life with. Good-humoured, a little lonely, decent.
- **DEV** — early 20s, junior IT support, works under Tilly. Eager, anxious, comic relief.
- **MAUREEN** — 50s, Tilly and Gaz's line manager / Head of Operations at the hotel company. Under pressure from above.
- **THE VOICE** — unseen. Heard only as a synthesised text-to-speech voice, or read from a screen. The hacker. Never appears in person.

A NOTE ON THE TWO UNSEEN VOICES

Pam and The Voice are the only two characters the audience never sees, and that's deliberate — one call pulls Tilly back towards herself, the other tries to pull her away. Both should come from the same place, technically speaking (a phone/speaker on or near Tilly), so the audience's ear has to do real work telling them apart. Pam should sound like an actual woman on a phone — ideally live off-stage, warm, occasionally cutting out, ordinary. The Voice should sound nothing like a person at all.

SETTING

Almost the entire play takes place in one flexible space that serves as the open-plan office of Bellhaven Hotel Group, with a second, smaller area — a kitchen table, a lamp, a laptop — that serves as Tilly's flat. Lighting, not scenery, should do the work of moving between them; the two areas can coexist on stage throughout, one lit and one dark, so there is never a full blackout-and-reset between scenes. A phone or a laptop is the only prop that needs to travel.

TIME

Present day. Action takes place over roughly ten days.

ACT ONE

SCENE ONE — THE OFFICE

Lights up on the office — desks, monitors, a kettle and a couple of mugs somewhere that stands in for the “kitchen corner,” so the office never needs to become a separate canteen set. TILLY is at her desk. DEV is nearby, over-explaining something to nobody in particular. GAZ leans against a filing cabinet with a coffee, phone in hand, mid-scroll.

GAZ. Right. Firing squad. Both of you. Photo one or photo three.

DEV. *(not looking up)* Depends what you’re going for.

GAZ. A bloke. Ideally one bloke, long-term, who doesn’t leave after the second date because I mentioned the trampoline unprompted.

TILLY. You mention the trampoline unprompted?

GAZ. It comes up organically!

TILLY. Nothing about a full-grown man doing star jumps in his garden at six a.m. comes up organically, Gaz.

GAZ. It is not star jumps, it is a *discipline*, there’s a whole competitive circuit, I could’ve represented the region —

DEV. *(finally looking up, delighted)* Wait, is this the thing where you nearly went to the Nationals?

GAZ. I did go to the Nationals. I came eleventh. Out of eleven. But I *went*.

TILLY. *(laughing despite herself)* Show me photo one.

GAZ holds his phone out. TILLY squints.

TILLY. *(cont’d)* Gaz. You’re mid-run in that one and your face has gone a colour I’d associate with a medical emergency.

GAZ. That’s my “determined” face.

TILLY. That’s your “I have gone off at the wrong pace and I am regretting everything” face. I’ve seen it before. You did it at the summer fun run.

DEV. Ohh, was that the one where you actually threw up behind the —

GAZ. We don’t talk about the fun run.

TILLY. We absolutely talk about the fun run, it’s the department’s finest hour.

GAZ. *(pocketing phone, mock-wounded)* Fine. See if I invite either of you to the wedding.

DEV. Whose wedding?

GAZ. *Hypothetical future wedding*, Dev, keep up.

DEV wanders off with his laptop, muttering something about the printer again. GAZ settles properly, drops the joking a notch.

GAZ. *(cont’d)* How’s things anyway. Properly, I mean. Not “fine, you?”

TILLY. Properly? Knackered. Lottie’s got a photography thing at school on Friday — she wants to enter this competition, actual proper thing, a local paper’s running it, and she needs a decent print made, and the good printer’s at the library because obviously mine died the week she needed it.

GAZ. She still doing the — the photography stuff, always got that camera glued to her hand?

TILLY. Obsessed. I got her a secondhand one for her birthday, thought it’d last a week. She’s been at it eight months. Better eye than me, if I’m honest, and I actually trained for this.

GAZ. That’s brilliant, though.

TILLY. It is. She’s decided she’s outgrown the camera I got her, mind — wants a proper zoom lens for the next one, and that’s not exactly forty quid down the market, so.

GAZ. She’ll win it. Local paper competitions, they love a kid with a proper eye.

TILLY. *(a real, tired smile)* I hope so. She deserves — I don’t know. Something going right that isn’t just me scraping it together at the last minute.

Beat. MAUREEN enters briskly, phone in hand, and the tone shifts — GAZ straightens slightly, professional-adjacent.

MAUREEN. Morning. Tilly, have you got five minutes? Gaz, don’t leave, this involves your lot too, might as well save myself the walk.

GAZ. Ominous.

MAUREEN. *(not quite joking)* Little bit, yeah. The board’s approved the AI rollout properly now — guest services chatbot goes live this month, that’s yours, Gaz — revenue forecasting, that’s more Tilly’s world — and there’s a line in the paperwork about “reviewing duplicated technical roles” that I wanted you to hear from me before it lands in an email at half four on a Friday like it always does.

GAZ. Duplicated meaning what, exactly?

MAUREEN. Duplicated meaning nobody’s said “redundancies” out loud yet, which in my experience means somebody’s already written the list.

TILLY. *(flat)* Reassuring.

MAUREEN. I’m not saying anything’s decided. I’m saying: don’t be blindsided.

GAZ. My team’s already nervous about the chatbot. Half of them think it’s there to replace them, other half think it’s there to annoy guests into ringing us anyway, which, frankly, tracks.

MAUREEN. Probably both. *(to Tilly)* You’re good at your job. That’s not nothing.

TILLY. It might be nothing, though. Doesn’t matter how good you are if the thing doing it is free and never sleeps and doesn’t need to leave early for a parents’ evening.

MAUREEN. *(gentler, tired herself)* I asked the chatbot what its pronouns were, as a joke, last week. It apologised to me. I don’t know what to do with that information and neither do you, so — heads down, numbers good, that’s the only advice I’ve got today.

MAUREEN exits. GAZ and TILLY sit with it a beat.

GAZ. She’s not wrong that it’s coming for both of us, is she.

TILLY. No.

GAZ. Cheerful start to the week. *(gathering himself, standing)* Right. I’ve got a customer screaming about a mini-bar charge from 2019, apparently, so. Onward.

He exits. TILLY turns back to her screen, the smile fading slower this time. She starts working. A beat. DEV approaches, laptop held slightly away from himself, the way you’d carry something that might be about to explode.

DEV. Tilly. Can I show you something. And can you promise not to shout before you’ve heard the whole thing.

TILLY. *(not looking up)* That’s never a good opener, Dev.

DEV. No, I know, I know, but — look, I was just doing the overnight ticket queue, routine stuff, and there’s a login on the guest database at half three this morning. Which, fine, sometimes that’s just the backup job. Except the backup job ran at half three *yesterday* as well, and the one before that, and it’s never done that before, it’s always the same time every night, like clockwork, and this is —

TILLY. *(cutting in, now looking up properly)* Show me.

He sets the laptop in front of her. She scrolls, frowning.

DEV. I didn’t touch anything, by the way. I want that on the record before you say anything else.

TILLY. Nobody said you touched anything.

DEV. You’ve got a face like someone touched something.

TILLY. *(still scrolling, half to herself)* This isn’t the backup job. The backup job doesn’t authenticate like this. This is a real login, with real credentials, at half three in the morning, three nights running.

DEV. Is that — is that bad? On a scale of “mildly annoying” to “front page of a newspaper”?

TILLY. *(typing now, faster)* Whose credentials?

DEV. I didn’t check whose, I just saw the pattern and came straight to you, I thought that was the sensible —

TILLY. It was. That was exactly the right thing to do. *(reading)* This is — hang on. *(a chill)* Dev, there’s an outbound transfer running. Right now. Not three nights ago. Now.

DEV. Now-now?

TILLY. Now-now. Card data. Addresses. Passport scans off the corporate bookings, going out the door as we speak.

DEV. *(pale)* Do we — do we call someone?

TILLY. We call everyone. *(already moving, grabbing her phone, then pausing half a second to look at him)* Good catch, Dev. I mean it. Most people would’ve closed that tab and made a tea.

DEV. *(caught between terrified and delighted)* I did also nearly make a tea.

TILLY. Tea after. Come on.

Lights hold tight on the two of them at the screen for a moment — the office around them dimming but not vanishing — as we move into—

SCENE TWO — TILLY’S FLAT

The second area of the set: a small kitchen table, a lamp, a laptop closed on the table. TILLY enters, coat still half on, drops into

a chair, exhausted. She picks up her phone, dials, puts it on the table between herself and the audience — PAM’s voice comes through, warm, a little tinny, unmistakably real rather than synthetic — the opposite of THE VOICE we’ll hear later.

PAM. *(on phone)* There she is. You sound like something the cat dragged in and thought better of.

TILLY. Cheers, Mum.

PAM. *(on phone)* Is Lottie asleep?

TILLY. Out like a light. Filled about half her memory card at the park today. I said, love, you don’t need a photo of every single pigeon in the borough.

PAM. *(on phone, smiling audibly)* She gets that from you. You used to fill whole albums with photos of the washing line.

TILLY. The washing line had *character*.

Beat. Her tone shifts.

PAM. *(on phone)* Go on then. What’s happened.

TILLY. Nothing’s happened.

PAM. *(on phone)* Tilly Anne.

TILLY. *(sighs)* Work’s a mess. There’s been a security thing — a breach. Somebody got into the systems, I caught it mid-transfer, and now it’s IT security and probably the police and it’s going to be weeks of this. And on top of it Maureen told me today they’re reviewing the whole department because of the AI rollout. Not might. Are.

PAM. *(on phone, careful)* Well. You’ve always landed on your feet.

TILLY. Have I, though? Or have I just not fallen yet. I keep doing the maths on Lottie’s competition print and the school trip in October and the boiler that’s been making that noise since March, and every single sum ends with “and what if I don’t have a job by Christmas.”

PAM. *(on phone)* When I lost the job at the print works — you were about Lottie’s age — I thought that was it. The end of everything. I was on the shop floor within six weeks and I’ve been standing behind a till ever since. Twenty-nine years. Not the job I dreamed of. But it’s a job. You find something.

TILLY. You’re retiring soon, though. Sixty-six before you can even touch the state pension.

PAM. *(on phone, brushing it off, not quite convincingly)* I’ve got a bit put by. Not a lot. Enough.

TILLY. Enough for what, Mum? Enough not to worry, or enough to just about get by and worry quietly so I don’t fuss?

PAM. *(on phone, honest)* The second one. But I’d rather worry quietly than have you worrying loudly on top of it. Doesn’t help either of us, more noise.

TILLY. I hate that everyone my age has no money and everyone your age has no time left to fix it.

PAM. *(on phone, dry)* Very cheerful. Go and have a biscuit, you sound like you need one. And kiss Lottie for me in the morning — tell her Grandma wants to see this pigeon photo, it had better be the best pigeon in England for all that camera gear we’re saving up for.

TILLY. *(small, real laugh)* Night, Mum.

PAM. *(on phone)* Night, love.

The line clicks off. TILLY sits with the dead phone in her hand a moment, then rubs her face. Lights fade on this area, hold on the office.

SCENE THREE — THE OFFICE, LATE

Evening. The office is empty but for TILLY, alone at her desk, lit by monitor glow. THE VOICE is heard — a flat, synthesised text-to-speech tone, coming from her computer speakers, unhurried. It should sound nothing like Pam did — no warmth, no static, no human catch in it at all.

THE VOICE. Hello, Tilly.

TILLY freezes.

TILLY. *(to the empty room)* Dev, if this is you, it’s not funny.

THE VOICE. It’s not Dev. You closed the connection quickly. Cleanly. Most people don’t notice for days. You noticed in eleven minutes.

TILLY. *(typing, trying to trace, failing)* Who is this.

THE VOICE. A name won’t help either of us. Call me a contractor. I’m going to make you an offer, and then I’m going to leave, and you can think about it.

TILLY. I’m calling the police.

THE VOICE. You can. They’ll trace this to a server in a country that won’t answer their emails. Meanwhile — I still have a copy of everything I pulled before you shut me out. Eleven minutes is fast, Tilly. It isn’t instant.

A beat. TILLY’s hand hovers over the keyboard.

THE VOICE. *(cont’d)* Here’s the offer. I don’t want the data anymore, not really — it’s low-grade, it’s a hotel chain, not a bank. What I want is a door left open. One config file, one afternoon, somewhere in your logs that never gets looked at twice. In exchange, fifty thousand pounds, in whatever form you like, and I disappear, and the copy I have gets deleted, and nobody outside this conversation ever knows there was a choice to make.

TILLY. And if I say no?

THE VOICE. Then I publish what I have. Guest data, corporate bookings — including several bookings made under company directors’ personal cards. That tends to get noticed by boards. And somewhere in the fallout, someone will ask how a breach sat undetected on your watch for eleven whole minutes, and whether the very clever programmer who found it quite so fast might have found it because she put it there.

TILLY. That’s not true.

THE VOICE. It doesn’t need to be true. It needs to be plausible for exactly as long as it takes a company already looking to cut your role to decide you’re more trouble than you’re worth. You’ll be unemployed either way, Tilly. I’m just offering you a version where you’re unemployed with fifty thousand pounds and no criminal record, instead of unemployed with neither.

Silence. TILLY stares at the screen.

THE VOICE. *(cont’d)* Think about it. I’ll be in touch. Say hello to your daughter for me — sweet age for the photography, isn’t it. Easy to find, this sort of thing, when a person over-shares. Camera settings, mostly, in the photo metadata. You should turn that off.

The tone cuts out. TILLY sits very still. Then, quickly, she checks her phone — old photos, scrolling, checking. Her breathing changes. Lights fade slowly to black.

END OF ACT ONE

ACT TWO

SCENE FOUR — THE OFFICE

Morning, a couple of days later. TILLY is at her desk, hollow-eyed, going through the motions. DEV is nearby, more subdued than before but trying, gently, to bring some normality back.

DEV. You look like you haven't slept.

TILLY. I haven't slept.

DEV. Do you want a tea? I can do a tea. I can't do coffee, the machine's still broken, but I can do a tea with real conviction. Owed you one anyway — you never let me have that one after the whole database thing.

TILLY. *(the smallest smile)* Go on then. And Dev — for what it's worth, I still think you're the reason this didn't get a lot worse than it did. Catching it when you did.

DEV. *(pleased, awkward with it)* I mainly just didn't want to be the one who broke it *again*. But I'll take the credit.

He busies himself at the kettle. GAZ enters, holding a printed report, visibly stressed — a different energy from the top of the play.

GAZ. Tilly. Have you seen this?

TILLY. Seen what?

GAZ. Guest complaints. Started yesterday. Three of my team have taken calls from people saying they've had odd card activity since staying with us. One woman's had her card cloned and used in a country she's never been to.

TILLY. *(a chill)* That's fast. Faster than it should be if I shut the connection down properly.

GAZ. Did you not shut it down properly?

TILLY. I shut down what I could see. *(quiet, half to herself)* Unless there was more than one door.

GAZ. *(watching her)* Tilly. You've gone a funny colour. What aren't you telling me?

TILLY. *(a beat — does she tell him?)* Nothing. It's just a lot right now. The department review. This. All of it at once.

GAZ. *(sitting on the edge of her desk, gentler, joking dropped entirely)* You know, for what it's worth — and I say this as a man who has personally embarrassed himself on four different dating apps this month — you don't have to have it all figured out on your own. I know we're not the same department, but you're one of about three people in this building I actually trust. If something's going on, I'm not going anywhere.

TILLY. *(genuinely moved, and torn)* Why are you being nice to me, I'm supposed to be having a private crisis.

GAZ. *(shrugs, warm)* Bad habit. Ask my last three dates. *(beat, gentler)* But I mean it, Tilly. Whatever this is.

A pause. TILLY almost tells him. Doesn't — not yet.

TILLY. Can I ask you something instead. Hypothetically.

GAZ. Go on.

TILLY. If you found out some money would fix everything — properly fix it, not just tide you over — but taking it meant letting something bad happen to people who trusted you. People you'd never meet. Would you be able to live with that? Even if nobody ever found out it was you?

GAZ. *(thinks properly, doesn't rush it)* I think the not-getting-found-out bit is doing a lot of work in that question. I reckon you'd know. Even if not one other soul on earth ever found out. You'd know, every single day, and I don't think I'm built to carry something like that around and still sleep right. *(beat)* Why, are you thinking of robbing a bank?

TILLY. *(a small, real laugh, despite everything)* Something like that.

GAZ. Well. For the record — I think you're one of the most decent people I know. Whatever it is. I don't reckon you're capable of the bad version of that hypothetical.

He gets up, squeezes her shoulder briefly. DEV hands her a tea on his way past, awkward and well-meaning. GAZ exits. TILLY sits with the tea going cold, then pulls her keyboard towards her and starts typing — fast, focused. Lights narrow on her.

SCENE FIVE — TILLY'S FLAT, NIGHT

Late. TILLY at the kitchen table, laptop open, phone beside it. She dials. PAM's voice again — real, warm, a little sleepy this time.

PAM. *(on phone)* Tilly? It's gone eleven, love, is everything alright?

TILLY. *(a long beat, then it spills)* The breach at work. It's worse than I thought. Whoever got in, they contacted me directly. Tonight — well, two nights ago now. They know things about me. About Lottie. They want me to leave a door open for them —

some access thing, technical, small — and they'll pay me fifty thousand pounds and disappear. And if I say no, they'll leak everything and make it look like it was me all along.

PAM. *(on phone, quiet)* Fifty thousand pounds.

TILLY. I know.

PAM. *(on phone)* That's not nothing, Tilly. That's not "buy a nicer telly" money. That's most of your mortgage gone. That's Lottie's whole childhood without you doing sums at midnight. Years of breathing room, if this AI business does take your job.

TILLY. *(shocked)* Mum.

PAM. *(on phone)* I'm not saying do it! I'm saying — I understand why a person would look at that number, on a bad week, with a kid to think about, and feel the shape of it in their hand before they've even decided anything.

TILLY. If I do it, I'm helping a criminal steal people's information. Actual people. Grandads going to weddings. Families on holiday.

PAM. *(on phone)* I know.

TILLY. And if I don't do it, they leak it anyway, and make it look like it was my fault, and I lose my job in disgrace instead of just quietly, and nobody will hire someone who got fired for a data breach, AI or no AI. And then what does Lottie get. A mum with no job and no name worth anything, instead of a mum with no job and fifty grand.

PAM. *(on phone, gently)* Then it sounds to me like you already know it isn't really about the fifty thousand pounds.

TILLY. What do you mean?

PAM. *(on phone)* I mean whichever way you look at that offer, it ends with you a little bit ruined. The only difference is whether you're ruined with money or ruined without it. That's not a business deal, love. That's a trap with a bow on it.

TILLY is quiet, absorbing this.

PAM. *(on phone, cont'd)* When I was frightened about money — properly frightened, after your dad went — do you know what got me through it? It wasn't a clever plan. It was that I could still look people in the eye. I could still stand behind that till and know I hadn't done anything I'd have to hide. That's worth more than you think, when everything else has gone a bit wobbly. It might be the only thing that's actually yours to give Lottie, in the end — not the fifty grand. That.

TILLY. *(quiet)* I'm scared, Mum.

PAM. *(on phone)* I know you are. So am I. Doesn't mean we do the wrong thing quietly and call it sensible.

A long held moment. TILLY nods, though Pam can't see it.

TILLY. Love you. Go to bed.

PAM. *(on phone, a small laugh)* Love you too. Kiss Lottie in the morning.

The line clicks off. TILLY sits a moment — then the electronic tone sounds again, immediate, jarring against the warmth that was just in the room. THE VOICE returns.

THE VOICE. You've had your time, Tilly. I need an answer.

TILLY. *(steady, though her hands aren't)* I know what you did with the extra access. My colleague's team has had guests reporting cloned cards already. That's not "low-grade hotel data," that's live fraud, right now, today.

THE VOICE. That's business moving quickly. It happens.

TILLY. I want you to know I've spent the last two days thinking about the fifty thousand pounds. Properly thinking about it. What it would do for my daughter. What it would mean not to be frightened for a while, for both of us.

THE VOICE. Good. Then you understand the offer's real.

TILLY. I do. And I've decided.

A beat. She doesn't say it. She turns to the keyboard instead and types a single word into the chat window — we hear the keys, nothing more, no line spoken. She hits enter.

THE VOICE. *(a pause — the length of time it takes a message to land on the other end — then, flat, as if reading it straight off the screen)* "No."

THE VOICE. *(cont'd)* You understand what happens next.

TILLY. I understand what you say happens next. Here's what I know instead. I've spent the last six hours with our security team and a police cybercrime unit, tracing every connection you've made to our systems since Tuesday — including the one you're using right now, which, for someone so confident, you really should not have reused. It's being logged as we speak. I also flagged every one of those personal-card corporate bookings myself, before you could dangle them at me as a threat — so that particular leverage is gone. And I've told my manager everything. Tonight. Before you even called.

Silence from THE VOICE for the first time.

TILLY. *(cont'd)* You picked me because you thought I was frightened enough to be quiet. I am frightened. Most days, if I'm honest — about my job, about money, about what happens to my daughter if being good at something stops mattering because a

machine can do it cheaper and never gets tired and never has a kid to pick up from school. But frightened isn't the same as for sale. You got that wrong.

THE VOICE. *(cold, quieter)* This isn't finished.

TILLY. Maybe not. But it isn't a secret anymore either, and secrets were the only thing you actually had.

The tone cuts out abruptly. Silence. TILLY doesn't move for a long moment. No relief in it — just the sudden, ringing quiet of a decision that can't be taken back. She looks at the phone, considers calling Pam again, doesn't. She just sits, laptop still open, cursor blinking in the empty chat window. Lights fade slowly — not gently, but slowly, holding on her stillness.

SCENE SIX — THE OFFICE, A WEEK LATER

Daylight, but the office feels thinner than before — a couple of desks visibly empty, one with a cardboard box half-packed on it. DEV is at his desk, quieter than before, not making jokes. MAUREEN crosses through, tired, and stops by TILLY's desk.

MAUREEN. Police still don't have him. Her. Them. Whoever. The trail you gave them went cold at some server in a country that isn't returning calls, same as everyone said it would.

TILLY. So it just — sits there. Open.

MAUREEN. For now. *(a beat)* The guests who had cards cloned are being compensated. That's something. Small something.

TILLY. And the review?

MAUREEN. *(not meeting her eye, at first)* Tilly —

TILLY. Just tell me.

MAUREEN. The board's still cutting the department. Not because of what you did — everyone upstairs knows exactly what you did, and there was a lot of noise for about three days about how it should protect you. But the forecasting tool's live now, and it's cheaper, and boards don't so much care why a thing was caught as whether they can avoid paying someone to catch the next one. Dev's role's safe. Yours is one of the two they're still deciding on.

TILLY. *(quiet)* After all that.

MAUREEN. I fought for you. I want you to know I fought for you. I don't know if it'll matter.

MAUREEN doesn't have anything else to offer. She touches Tilly's shoulder, briefly, and exits. DEV glances over but doesn't come across this time — just an awkward, sympathetic nod, back to his screen. TILLY sits with it, then quietly takes her phone out and looks at something on it — a photo, we can guess, though we never see it. A small, private smile crosses her face despite everything, there and gone.

GAZ enters, quieter than we've seen him, phone in his pocket rather than in his hand.

GAZ. Heard about the review.

TILLY. Word travels.

GAZ. *(sitting near her, not performing anything)* For what it's worth — and I know it might not be worth much right now — I still think you did the right thing. I've thought about your hypothetical about nine times a day since.

TILLY. Doesn't feel like the right thing today. Feels like I did the right thing and got the same ending anyway. Maybe worse, because now it's public that it happened at all.

GAZ. Maybe. *(honest, not comforting for the sake of it)* I don't know how it ends either, Tilly. I'm not going to sit here and tell you it definitely works out, because I don't know that. Nobody does. That match, by the way — the trampoline one. Went quiet after two messages. So. We're both sat here not knowing things.

TILLY. *(a small, tired, real laugh — the first crack of light in a while)* Comforting.

GAZ. I try. *(beat)* How's Lottie's competition thing? The pigeon photo?

TILLY. *(the smile holds, just)* Results Friday. She's already decided she's won. I haven't got the heart to tell her that's not how competitions work.

GAZ. Let her have it. Sounds like she's earned a bit of certain good news, whatever else is up in the air.

TILLY. *(quiet)* Yeah. She has.

A beat. He doesn't try to fix anything further — just stays, sitting near her, the two of them looking at the half-packed box on the empty desk across the room.

GAZ. *(cont'd, quieter)* You going to be alright?

TILLY. *(a long pause — she doesn't perform an answer, doesn't reach for a neat one)* I don't know yet. Ask me in a month.

Lights hold on the two of them, not touching, just present, the ordinary hum of the office continuing around them — phones ringing somewhere, a printer, the low murmur of people still doing their jobs while other people wonder if they'll still have theirs. No music swells. Nothing resolves. The lights simply fade, slowly, to black — leaving the question of what happens to

Tilly, and whether doing right cost her everything, unanswered.

END OF PLAY

Running time: flexible — roughly 70-80 minutes with the expanded opening, though scenes can be trimmed back toward an hour if needed.

Note on staging: because Pam and The Voice are both unseen, resist any temptation to give Pam a “phone effect” filter on her mic — the more ordinary and human she sounds, the harder The Voice should land by comparison.

Note on the ending: this version is deliberately unresolved. Tilly’s job, the hacker’s fate, Lottie’s competition, and Gaz’s prospects are all left open — the intention is that the audience leaves carrying the same uncertainty Tilly does, rather than being reassured that integrity was rewarded. If a director wants a harder landing still, Scene Six can end on Maureen’s line “I don’t know if it’ll matter,” cutting straight to blackout before Gaz enters at all.